

With manual control, you can experiment, and capture what the Auto mode will not

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Are you one of those who would love to get friendlier with your digicam but find that the menus and acronyms are just too confusing to bother with—and simply use the Auto setting on your camera? Many people do not realise the true potential of their camera and tend to do this.

It's true that most of the default settings in cameras these days work just fine, and the hassle of tweaking puts people off of the manual controls. But with manual control, you can experiment, and capture what the Auto mode will not—especially when it comes to things such as shadows, lighting effects, black and white photography... Read on and find out how you can tweak

sensor) and the depth of the photograph.

This setting works in tandem with the shutter speed, so if you want shots of something moving fast, you should increase the aperture size and increase the shutter speed to minimise the blur. In fact, if you get the balance right, you can even get brilliant blur effects—like the ones you see on F1 posters!

Aperture Priority

You can select the desired aperture and the camera will automatically select the best shutter speed for it. (Some cameras will let you set both independently, but these are mostly professional cameras).

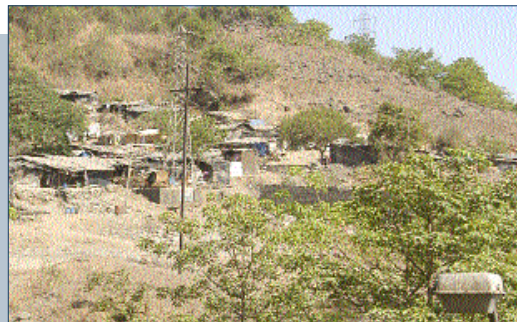
AE Lock

Automatic Exposure Locking is the ability to lock the aperture and shutter speed (and hence, Exposure) settings for a series of images. That is, for every image

sure value. Sometimes, though, it selects the wrong part, and your photo may turn out over- or under-exposed (depending on the selected area). To counter this, most cameras today let you change the wrongly-calculated exposure value using the EV (Exposure Value) compensation feature. The camera usually provides you with a slider operated by the 'navi' keys, and the EV compensation values range from -2 to +2 with incremental steps of 1/3.

Flash Output Compensation

Some cameras even allow you to determine the power of your flash. This means you can control the amount of light the flash emits when you shoot. This is helpful when, due to confusing light conditions, the flash metering (calculated automatically) goes awry.



An under-exposed image on the left vis-à-vis a correctly-exposed image on the right

those settings to get the best out of your digital camera.

Aperture Settings

The aperture is the size of the opening in the lens, which determines how much light received falls on the camera's sensor (in the case of digicams) or film (in the case of conventional cameras). This setting affects the exposure (the amount of light received by the

in the series, the aperture and shutter speed settings will be the same. This is extremely helpful if you are trying to merge multiple images together (while creating a 3D walkthrough, for example, or during the creation of a panoramic image).

Exposure Compensation

In Auto Mode, the camera basically selects a part of the image to determine the correct expo-

ISO

The ISO setting on your camera basically tells you how sensitive the camera sensor is to the light falling on it. Now, for regular film cameras, the ISO rating is on the film roll, but in digicams, the setting is related to the camera's sensor. As a thumb rule, the higher the ISO setting, the faster the shutter speed required. So, if the ISO setting is too high, you will start seeing a lot of noise and

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